

@RISHISUNAK/TWITTER

A HAPPY DIWALI **A picture of himself at a Diwali reception at 10, Downing Street that Sunak tweeted on October 26**

finalised. The Diwali deadline has passed, but that does not reflect any lack of interest or dilution of commitment on either side.

The other crucial pact that has to be implemented is the Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreement (MMPA) signed between India and the UK in May 2021. It takes a balanced approach to the twin issues that have impacted India-UK ties for years. One is facilitating legitimate movement of nationals between our countries to boost trade and foster closer cooperation in education and services. The other is cooperation on the 'return' of Indian nationals found to be illegally resident in the UK or who have overstayed their visas. The first step—establishment of a joint working group to work out the modalities of implementing the MMPA—has been patchy in execution.

Meanwhile, the UK Home Office seemed to focus on sending back Indians in an ad hoc manner. The remark about Indian nationals by Suella Braverman, home secretary under Liz Truss, that "the largest group of migrants who overstay are Indians", was received with dismay by those working for the success of the MMPA and the finalisation of the FTA, where smooth movement of students, professionals, service providers, workers and others between India and the UK is a central theme. Sunak has reappointed Braverman, and it is to be seen how she will handle this sensitive issue.

Commerce minister Piyush Goyal had rightly stated that it would be best to wait and see the new government's approach to the FTA: here, too, it may be anticipated that Sunak will send out an early signal for swift resumption, addressing 'difficult' chapters in a practical way. Sunak will, no doubt, bring his commitment, accountability and youthful passion to the job. Both he and his wife, the charmingly unassuming Akshata Murty (she surprised us by arriving without any fuss or protocol at the Indian High Commission and then preferred public transport while leaving), are proud of their Indian heritage. India, too, is proud of PM Rishi Sunak. We wish him success.

The writer, a retired IFS officer, is a former Indian high commissioner to the UK

to part with their money, and dull ones in the back room with their shirts buttoned up badly. Rishi was the first type," says Sumesh Puthiyaveetil, director of eXcentius, a firm that provides strategic tech due diligence and value creation for private equity.

It was at Stanford that Sunak met his wife Akshata Murty, daughter of Indian tech millionaire N.R. Narayana Murthy. The two were married in a two-day ceremony in Bengaluru in 2009. Sunak later brought her to Southampton, to the family temple he attended growing up and to Kuti's Brasserie, where he'd once laid tables as a young student. His former employer, Kuti Miah, catered Thai food at a 200-strong reception for Sunak. "The perfect son-in-law was soon made a director at Catamaran Investment, Murthy's private family investment vehicle. It showed how much Murthy trusted him with his money," says Puthiyaveetil. He was then parachuted to a Tory safe seat in Richmond, to the utter dismay of many Tory grandees. "Sunak's billionaire father-in-law, Narayana Murthy, however, was so enthusiastic about Sunak's parliamentary career that he had flown in, and had even been leafleting on his behalf, wearing a Rishi sweatshirt," says Ben Judah, British journalist and author of *This is London* and *Fragile Empire*. Sunak joked to his friends about him and his wife being the only immigrant population in the constituency. "To be honest," argued Sunak, "I think it's patronising to assume minorities should only run in minority seats." On May 7, 2015, Sunak won, with more than 50 per cent of the vote.

Sunak then backed the Brexit movement and, more importantly, backed Boris Johnson to the hilt. After Johnson deposed Theresa May as prime minister on July 20, 2019, he ensured that the Tories would return to power with a landslide victory in December that year. Johnson initially picked Sunak to be chief secretary of the Treasury and then made him Chancellor of the Exchequer (equivalent to the Union finance minister in India) after dropping Sajid Javid in February 2020. On average, British finance ministers have a cabinet experience of five years and will have spent at least 15 years in Parliament; Sunak came and wrote new rules for himself. He went off